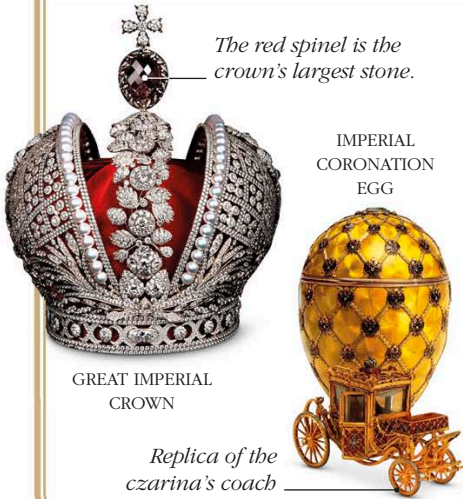


ROYAL REGALIA

Russian rulers were crowned in elaborate ceremonies. From the coronation of Catherine the Great in 1762 onward, all monarchs used the Great Imperial Crown, which was decorated with more than 5,000 gemstones. The last czar, Nicholas II, had the jeweled Imperial Coronation egg made for his wife, Czarina Alexandra, to celebrate his coronation.



The red spinel is the crown's largest stone.

IMPERIAL
CORONATION
EGG

GREAT IMPERIAL
CROWN

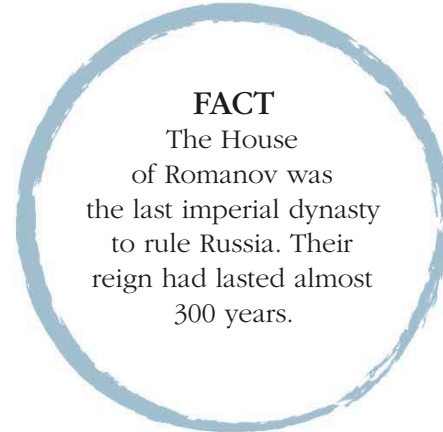
Replica of the
czarina's coach

THE LAST CZAR ▼

Nicholas II was a weak ruler, who refused to modernize his country and led Russia disastrously in World War I. He was overthrown during the revolution of 1917, and along with his family (below), killed in 1918.

▲ THE CRIMEAN WAR

In 1853, war broke out between Russia and an alliance of France, Britain, and the Ottoman Empire. Most of the fighting took place in the Crimean Peninsula in eastern Europe. The war was one of the first to use modern technologies such as railroads to transport ammunition, but ended in defeat for Russia.



FACT

The House of Romanov was the last imperial dynasty to rule Russia. Their reign had lasted almost 300 years.



CZARINA
ALEXANDRA

CZAR
NICHOLAS II

GRAND
DUCHESS MARIA

GRAND
DUCHESS
OLGA

GRAND DUCHESS
ANASTASIA

GRAND
DUCHESS
TATIANA

CZAREVITCH
ALEXEI

IMPERIAL RULERS

1762–1796

During the reign of Catherine the Great, the Russian Empire expands to the Black Sea coast, and takes in parts of Poland and Alaska.

1801–1825

Czar Alexander I comes to the throne after his father, Paul I, is killed. Early in his reign, he introduces many reforms that he overturns later in life.

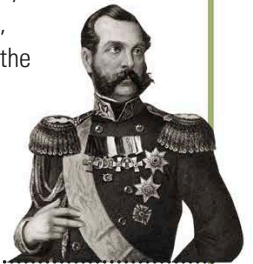
1825–1855

Czar Nicholas I takes the throne after surviving a military revolt against him. During his reign, Russia expands its borders further and develops industry.

1855–1881

Alexander II is a liberal ruler who brings in many reforms in Russia, including freeing the serfs in 1861. He is killed in 1881.

ALEXANDER II



1881–1894

Alexander III opposes any reform that limits his power and reverses many of the new laws introduced by his father.

1894–1917

After military losses, Nicholas II quickly loses popularity and is forced to leave the throne after the revolution of 1917.